

Alaska Airlines: Booking Flow Research

UXDE 5050 Design Research Feasibility: Final Project

Umaiya Sridas

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Background

This research was conducted to develop an understanding of the experience of an Alaska Airlines customer and identify pain points of the Alaska Airlines website booking flow. Using this information, we can seek out ways to increase completed bookings, improve attach rate, and reduce confusion when comparing fares and add-ons.

Study Details

Alaska Airlines Booking Flow Research: Executive Summary

We conducted 2 moderated and 4 unmoderated usability tests in order to learn about the Alaska Airlines website booking flow experience and its key pain points. We focused on the flight choice, seat choice, and add-on choice steps of the process to understand why users abandoned booking or did not consider attachments.

Users expend excess effort to navigate between flights.



P1 (Almost P0): High Priority

Address repeated navigation issues during the flight choice step by providing clearer navigation.

Lack of clarity and visibility of information about flight tiers leads to confusion and lack of confidence.



P1: High Priority

Edit the content of the transitional modal to provide details of the chosen flight tier.

Users overlook details because they do not want to expend extra mental effort finding hidden information.



P2: Future Roadmap

Reorganize seat selection to show flights on a single page and add a seat confirmation element.

Users prioritize price and default to habits when making decisions, unless they are confident they are getting a good deal.



P2: Future Roadmap

Move add-ons to a dedicated pre-checkout step.

Research Background

Research questions and tasks

Research questions

- What are the experiences of Alaska Airlines customers?
- What part of the booking flow is most confusing or difficult to complete?
- What discourages or limits customers from completing a booking?
- What discourages or limits customers from attaching add-ons?
- What does the customer like or want to see more of in the booking flow?
- What does the ideal booking flow look like?

Tasks

1. Choosing flights
2. Choosing seats
3. Choosing add-ons

Research methods

Moderated usability testing

- 2 moderated testers, both were recruited through personal connections

Unmoderated usability testing

- 4 UserBrain testers
 - 2 testers were recruited through UserBrain credits
 - 2 testers were recruited through personal connections

Participant Log

	WHERE ARE THEY FROM?	HOW DO THEY BOOK FLIGHTS?	WHEN DID THEY LAST FLY WITH ALASKA?
Participant #1 Moderated	U.S.A., lives in North Carolina, used to live in Alaska	Through an online aggregator or third party	1-2 years ago
Participant #2 Unmoderated	U.S.A.	Through an online aggregator or third party	1-2 years ago
Participant #3 Moderated	U.S.A., lives in Seattle, used to live in Hawaii	Through an airline app or website	Within the last 6 months
Participant #4 Unmoderated	Germany	Through an airline app or website	Within the last 6 months
Participant #5 Unmoderated	U.S.A.	Through an airline app or website	Within the last 6 months
Participant #6 Unmoderated	U.S.A.	Through an online aggregator or third party	Within the last 6 months

Key Insights

Users need to expend more effort and go back and forth to see flight details and compare flight information.

What are users doing?

During flight selection, users used back and forth navigation and trial and error to view and understand all their flight options.

- 3/6 users utilized trial and error to find their flights, clicking on different buttons to test the output
- 2/6 users went back and forth in navigation to see their flight options.
- Average confidence was 4.5 (out of 7), which was the lowest confidence of all tasks
- Average time was 4:36, by far the longest of all tasks

So what?

Friction during the flight choice step is causing **frustration** among users and increases the risk of **booking abandonment**, leading to **lost sales**.

“

[I] just had to **keep comparing back and forth** by pressing back and changing back my filters. There doesn't seem to be a back feature without having to go back to the main page... [it's] **annoying** if you are trying to compare two different flights.

”

Participant #6

Lack of clarity and visibility of information about flight tiers leads to confusion and lack of confidence in flight decisions.

What are users doing?

During flight selection, users were not confident in their decision and expressed confusion. Furthermore, some users failed the task by choosing non-refundable flights (Saver flights).

- Average confidence was 4.5 (out of 7), which was the lowest confidence of all tasks
- 3/6 verbally expressed confusion through the process
- This task had the lowest success rate, with 2/6 users failing to get flexible flights
- Average time was 4:36, by far the longest of all tasks
- 0/6 users clicked the “Compare flights” button to view tier differences

So what?

This lack of confidence could be the cause of **booking abandonment** during the flight choice step, leading to **lost sales and decreased trust**.

Insight #2

“

The main aspect [is] to have a flexible ticket, I'm not sure if it's included in the Saver class.

”

Participant #4

Sorted by: Stops ↑		Compare fares ✈	Saver	Main	Premium	Business
	AS 823	10h 30m +1 day	Saver	Main	Premium	Business
	1:30 pm SEA	4:00 pm NRT	\$1,780 Round trip	\$2,020 Round trip last 3 seats	\$2,435 Round trip last 3 seats	\$8,750 Round trip Lie-Flat
Nonstop						
Details Seats						

Saver ✈	Main ✈	Premium ✈	First/Business ✈
✗ No seat selection	✓ Seat selection in Main cabin	✓ Seat selection in Premium Class cabin	✓ Seat selection in First Class cabin
✗ Last to board	✓ General boarding	✓ Priority boarding	✓ Priority boarding
✗ Limited Atmos™ Rewards benefits	✓ Atmos™ Rewards benefits	✓ Atmos™ Rewards benefits	✓ Atmos™ Rewards benefits
✗ Flight changes	✓ No flight change fees	✓ No flight change fees	✓ No flight change fees
✗ Reduced points earned	✓ Points earned	✓ Points earned	✓ Points earned
		✓ Extra legroom	✓ Spacious seats
		✓ Free beer, wine and cocktails on 350+ mile flights	✓ Free meals and snacks
			✓ Free beer, wine, and cocktails
			✓ Free bags

0/6 users clicked the “Compare flights” button to view tier differences

Users do not want to expend extra mental effort to find unclear or hidden information and tend overlook details throughout the booking process.

What are users doing?

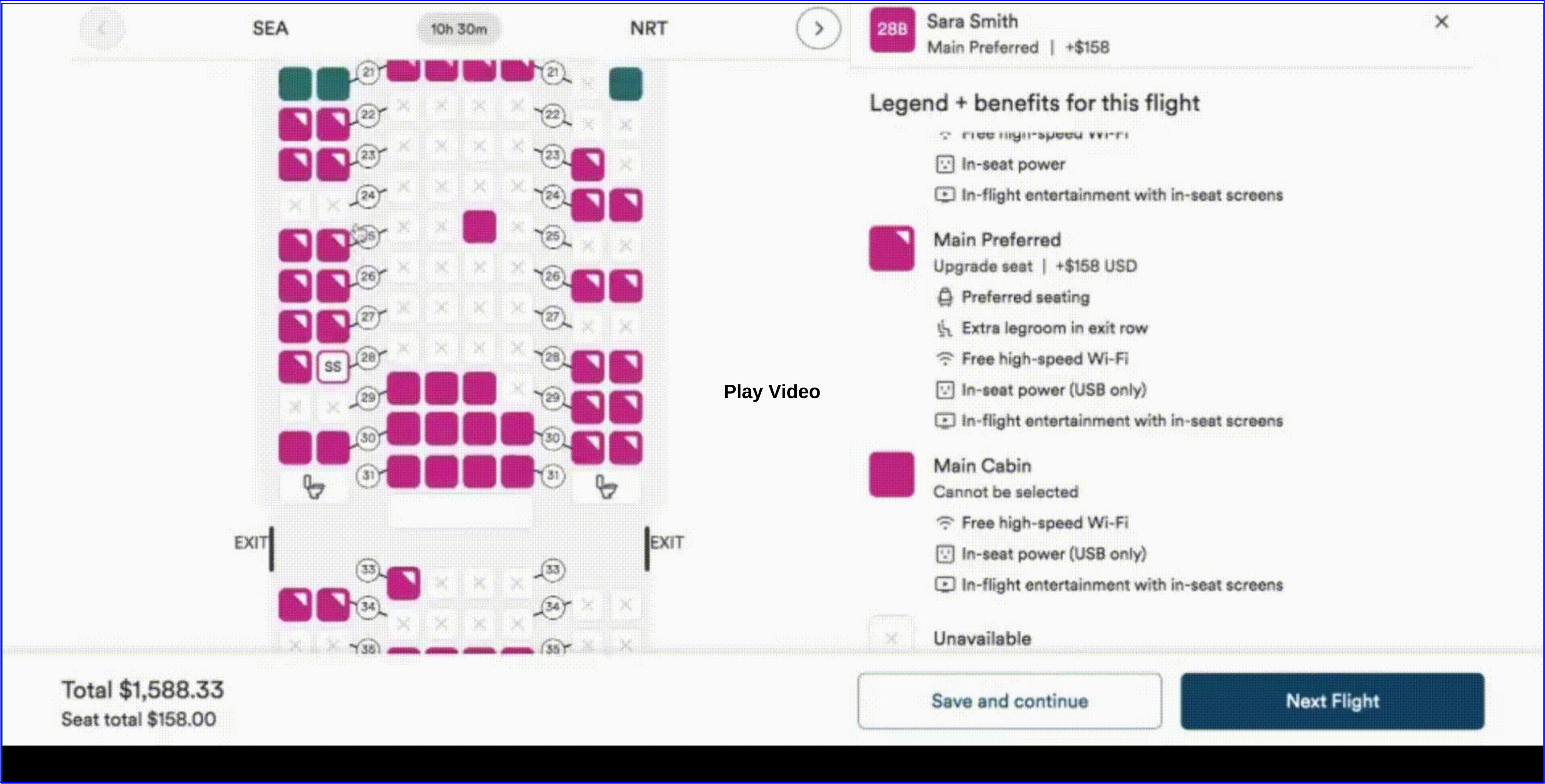
For seat selection and add-ons, users were confident and quick in decision making, even if they missed or overlooked details.

- 2/6 users were confident in their seats but missed seat selection for one leg of their flight
- 4/6 users overlooked the Atmos Rewards card
- Average confidence for choosing seats was ~6.3 (out of 7), the highest confidence of all tasks
- Average time for choosing seats was 1:36, the second shortest of all tasks
- Average confidence for choosing add-ons was 6.25 (out of 7), which was the second highest confidence of all tasks
- Average time for choosing add-ons was 1:09, the shortest of all tasks

So what?

Users **risk overlooking details** throughout the booking process due to the high cognitive load, **reducing potential attachments.**

Insight #3



This user **chose an upgraded seat** for her departure flight, but **skipped picking seats for the next flight**.
When asked, she said she didn't even notice that she did that.

Users prioritize price and default to habits when making decisions; they will avoid extra costs unless they are confident they are getting a good deal.

What are users doing?

All users stated price as a deciding factor for their decisions, looking for the “best deal”, “cheapest”, or “cost effective” options. Furthermore, users were confident in their seat selection and add-on selection and made quick decisions during these steps.

- Average confidence for choosing add-ons was 6.25 (out of 7), the second highest confidence of all tasks
- Average time for choosing add-ons was 1:09, the shortest of all tasks
- 6/6 users opted “NO” for travel insurance, although 2/6 users debated on it due to weather and it being an international flight and 1 user said he was burned by lack of insurance before

So what?

Without clear benefits of purchasing add-ons, users are **less confident** and therefore **not incentivized to increase attach rate**.

“
I would just say **no**. I just
never do it just because **it's a
habit. I don't think it's worth
it**. I've booked many flights in
the past. I've never needed it.”

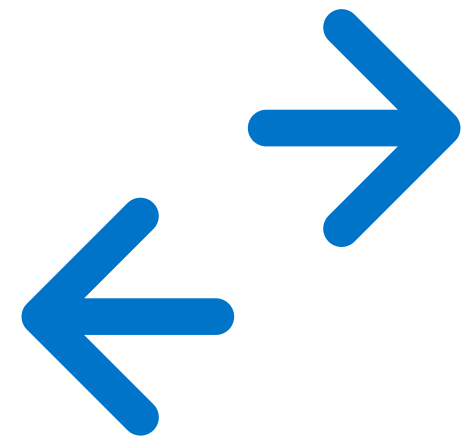
Participant #2

The screenshot displays a flight booking interface. At the top, there are two flight options: 'Seattle to NRT' (SEA - NRT) with a '23G' button, and 'NRT to Seattle' (NRT - SEA) with a '24G' button. Below these is a 'Travelers' section listing 'John Doe' as the 'Primary contact'. To the right is a 'Price summary' box showing 'Airfare' as '\$2,044.23' and a 'Total' of '\$2,044.23', with a 'Book now' button. The main section is titled 'Add travel insurance (recommended)' and includes a video player with a 'Play Video' button. Below the video, there is a 'Yes' button and a 'No' button. The 'Yes' option is highlighted with a 'Highly Recommended' badge and lists benefits: 'Get back up to 300% of your ticket cost if your trip is interrupted due to a covered illness or injury', 'Emergency medical care and transportation available in foreign countries for greater peace of mind', and '24/7 assistance to help with emergencies on the go'. A quote from FoxBusiness.com is also present. The 'No' option states: 'No, thank you. I understand my trip will not be protected.'

The decision to not add travel insurance was **made in seconds**.
The Atmos Rewards card was **completely overlooked**.

Overview of Insights

Insight #1



Users need to expend more effort and go back and forth to see flight details and compare flight information.

Insight #2



Lack of clarity and visibility of information about flight tiers leads to confusion and lack of confidence in flight decisions.

Insight #3



Users do not want to expend extra mental effort to find unclear or hidden information and tend to overlook details throughout the booking process.

Insight #4



Users prioritize price and default to habits when making decisions; they will avoid extra costs unless they are confident they are getting a good deal.

Recommendations & Prioritizations

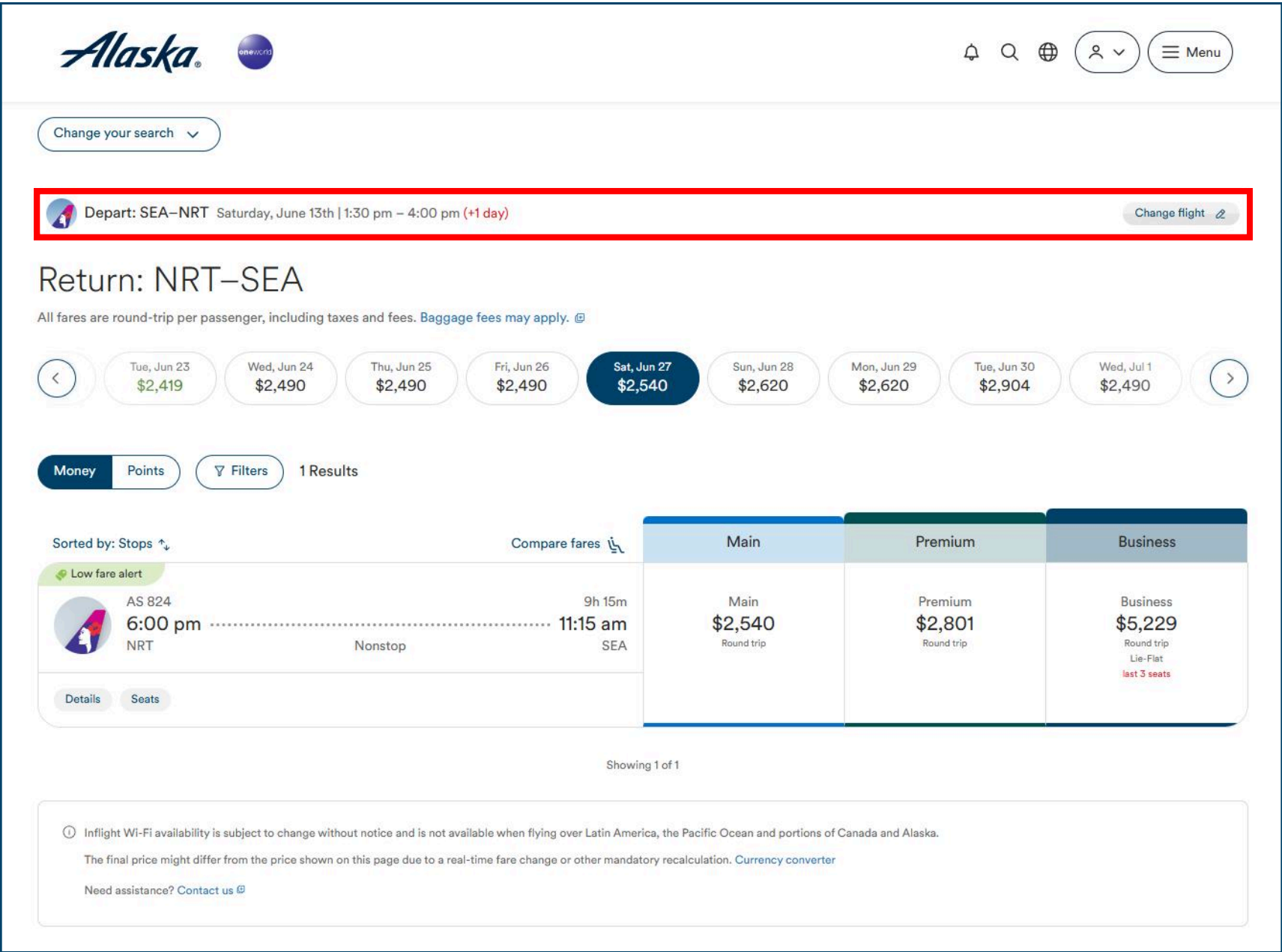
Overview of Recommendations & Priorities

Insight #1	P1 (Almost P0): High Priority	Insight #2	P1: High Priority	Insight #3	P2: Future Roadmap	Insight #4	P2: Future Roadmap
Fixing navigation difficulties Priority Reasoning • Current navigation functionality slows down task completion • Effort to provide visible navigation will not need too much extra design effort • Fixing navigation should be low effort	Providing flight information clarity Priority Reasoning • This task had the highest failure rate and had the lowest confidence rate • Effort to redesign the transitional modal may be high, but pay-off will be greater and will discourage abandonment	Increasing attachment visibility Priority Reasoning • We are losing seat attachments due to lack of visibility, not because users do not want to choose seats • This will require reviewing the entire seat selection page, which will be higher effort	Highlighting add-ons and presenting their value Priority Reasoning • This will require adding a new page or section to the booking flow, which will be high effort, but will increase add-on visibility, consideration, and interaction				

How might we enable users to view and compare flight information without unnecessary steps or navigation?

I recommend **providing a clear navigation component** in order to address **repeated navigation issues** during the flight choice step. This will help us **reduce frustration and flight choice step duration** so we can **increase completed bookings**.

Provide a clear navigation component



Users **clicked on the back button** of the browser rather than the “Change flight” button

How might we create clarity during the flight choice step in order to boost confidence in decisions?

I recommend **editing the content of the transitional modal to provide details of the chosen flight tier** because users **could not find basic tier information** when comparing flights. This will help **increase customer confidence and lower booking abandonment** so we can **increase completed bookings and trust among our customer base**.

Edit the content of the modal to provide details of the chosen flight tier

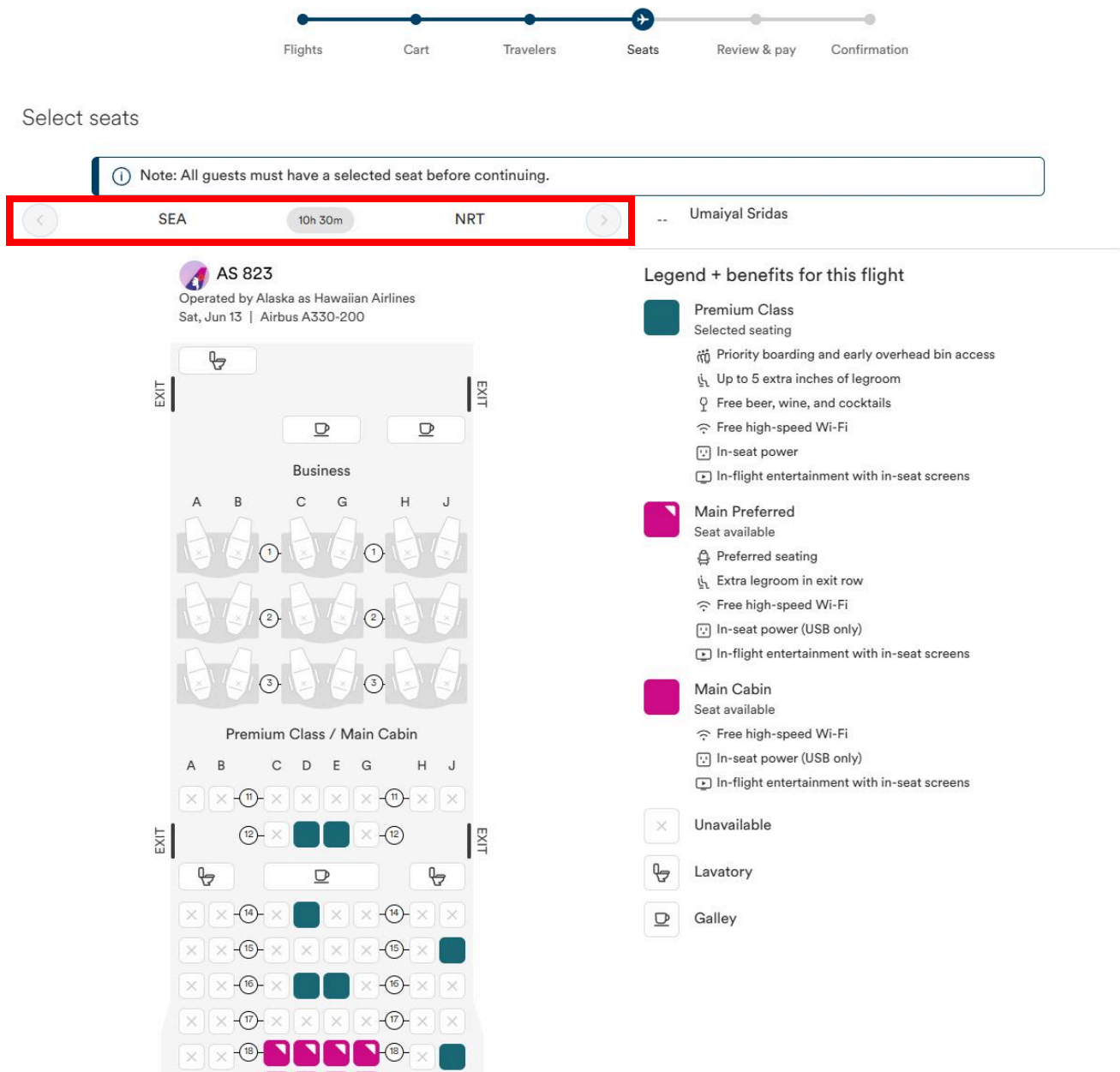
Saver 	Main 	Premium 	First/Business 
 No seat selection	 Seat selection in Main cabin	 Seat selection in Premium Class cabin	 Seat selection in First Class cabin
 Last to board	 General boarding	 Priority boarding	 Priority boarding
 Limited Atmos™ Rewards benefits	 Atmos™ Rewards benefits	 Atmos™ Rewards benefits	 Atmos™ Rewards benefits
 Flight changes	 No flight change fees	 No flight change fees	 No flight change fees
 Reduced points earned	 Points earned	 Points earned	 Points earned
		 Extra legroom	 Spacious seats
		 Free beer, wine and cocktails on 350+ mile flights	 Free meals and snacks
			 Free beer, wine, and cocktails
			 Free bags

Include details from the “Compare flights” chart

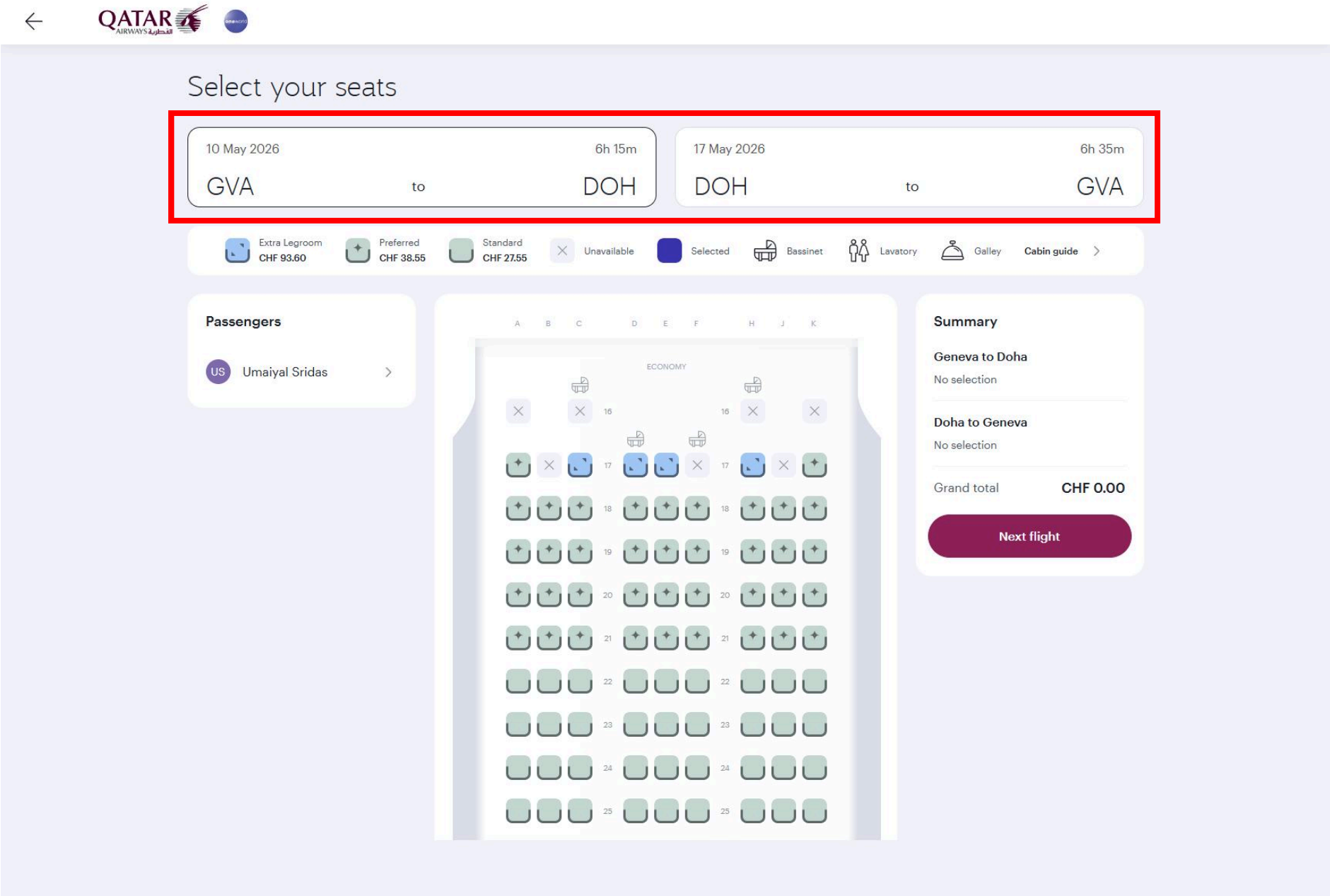
How might we reduce cognitive load and increase visibility of attachments so they are not overlooked?

I recommend emphasizing the leg of the flight a user is choosing seats for and adding a seat confirmation component in order to improve visibility and address accidentally missed seat selection. This will help us see an increased rate of completed seat selection so we can increase attachment rate.

Emphasize the leg of the flight a user is choosing seats for



It’s hard to tell which leg of the flight you are choosing seats for.

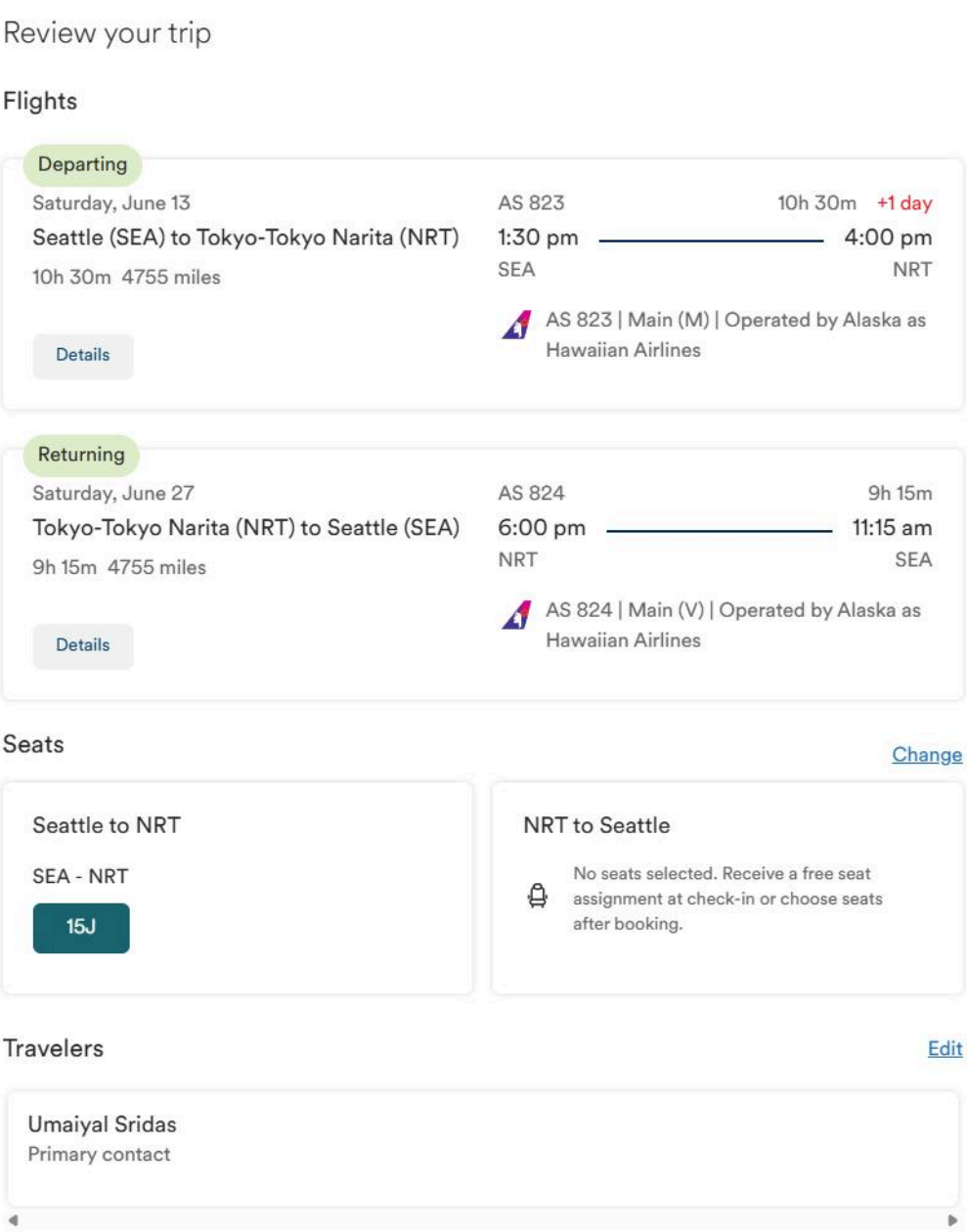


Qatar Airways shows both **departing and returning flights side by side** at the top.

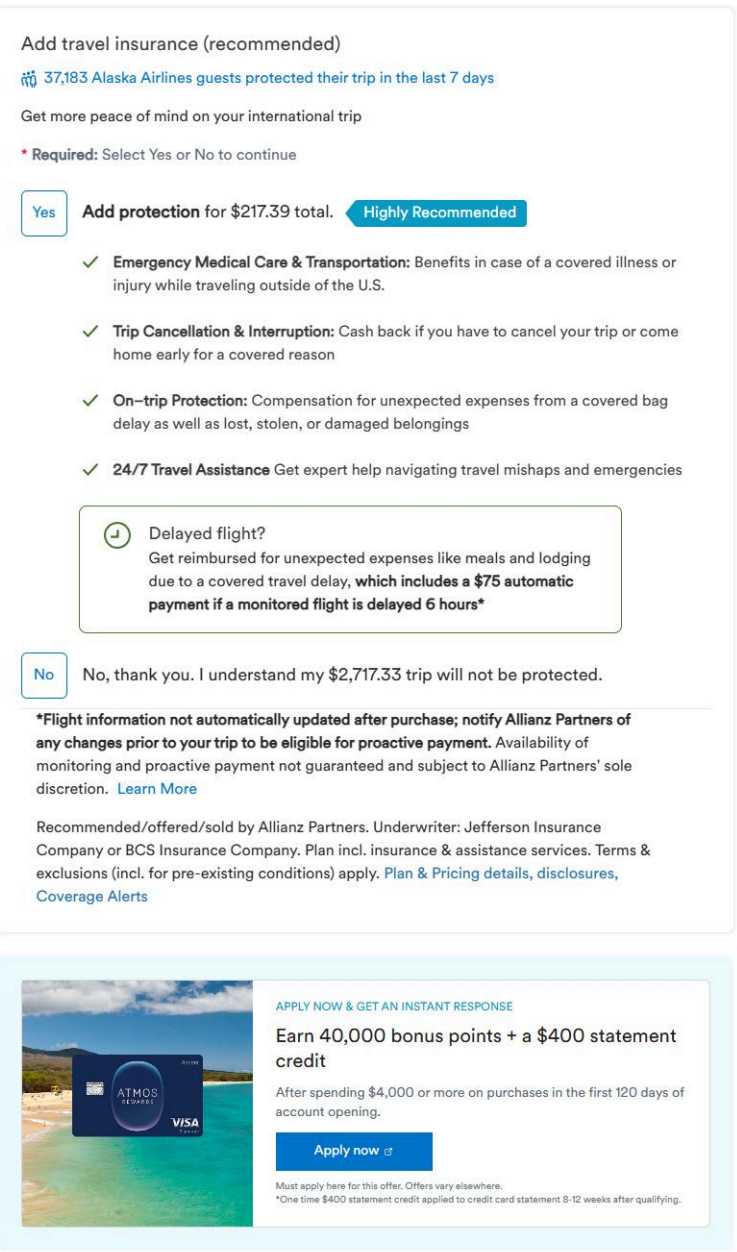
How might we highlight add-ons and show their value clearly so that users are willing to explore options outside of their habitual choices?

I recommend moving add-ons like travel insurance (with clear, contextual information such as weather and international travel indicators) and the Atmos Rewards card to a dedicated pre-checkout step, because users overlooked add-ons when it was interspersed with payment details. This will improve add-on visibility and consideration so we can increase attachment rate and Atmos Rewards plan enrollment.

Move add-ons to a dedicated pre-checkout step

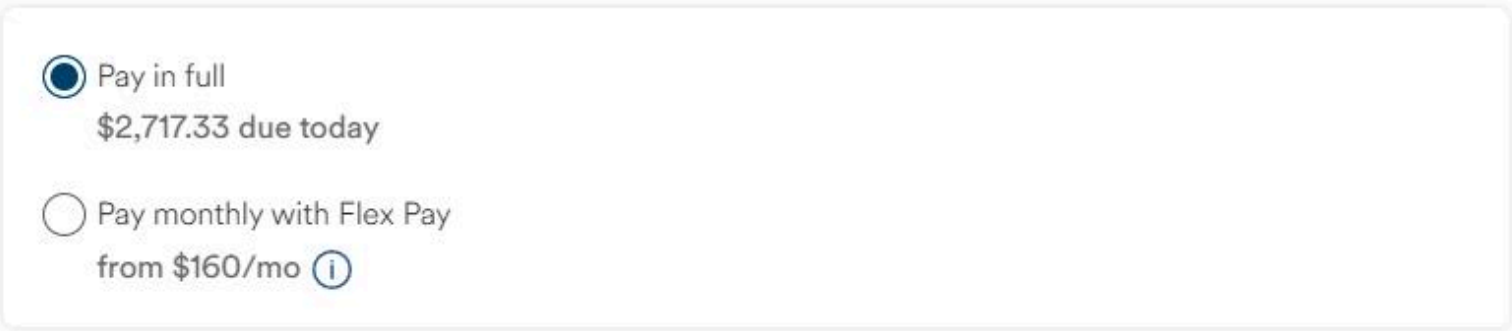


First main section on the checkout page: Review your trip



Second main section on the checkout page: Add-ons
This could be highlighted as its own section.

Choose payment



Pay with

[+ Add a gift certificate/card](#)



By purchasing, I have read and agree to the Travel Policies, [privacy notice](#), [Contract of Carriage](#), and [website terms of use](#). See terms and policies below.

Third main section on the checkout page: Payment

Reflection

Reflection

What went well?

- Conducting the usability tests and taking notes went well and I made tags that were short, yet understandable
- Extracting quotes, videos, and images to support insights was very easy and made my slide deck more interesting

What was difficult?

- Extracting insights into 3-5 concise and important groups, especially when features of the website were affected by multiple insights
 - In the future, I may have an extra blurb where I mention features that can be affected by multiple insight recommendations
- Interviewing with a neutral tone, while still probing for information

What did you learn?

- New methods of research, like heuristic evaluation, and triangulation of research methods
- Balancing voices of stakeholders and customers; ideally I'd love to make all changes a customer would benefit from, but that is not realistic within the confines of a business

Sources

Competitive Analysis Figma Board: <https://www.figma.com/design/yAd3ofiaQfFIAHm3K16tqy/UXDE5050-Assignment--1?node-id=0-1&t=nKJKYBbDWRMIItA8k-1>

Evaluative Test Plan: <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1QA0muMMtKup-VKS6oHYFtV9H12J8t7UG3OnlHa5Bs14/edit?usp=sharing>

Test Plan Figma Board: <https://www.figma.com/board/hzdIFfXE4Celvx8Ujvtp4j/UXDE5050-Assignment--2?node-id=0-1&t=QfRMSsmzfZ0yKJw4-1>

AI Stress-Test & Pilot Testing: <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1i6CJiuc-QWg3J-bygBQVKKdw2JHhIjNQuYESm-UVGck/edit?usp=sharing>

Recruiting & Conducting Usability Sessions: <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1sWgpE0pmpRxVbftOAdfVWvcOZdtKQO9uJChS5HIfkY/edit?usp=sharing>

Usability Tests Spreadsheet: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1f6YBgL7Ato_KGAoif9CefAPqZJ7_kdFxm_RoU5pX_uU/edit?usp=sharing

Capture Session Data & Analyze Feedback: <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1A0et2XVHaf9nhUusqNqaLIJ6HLgCg0jIS5utrjgfF-g/edit?usp=sharing>

Analysis Figma Board: <https://www.figma.com/design/1FNcV8Zz1hSOYu24CxSYy2/UXDE5050--Assignment--5?node-id=0-1&t=5VZzv0wPxjs5zySq-1>

Questions or comments?